THE UNIVERSITY OF HONG KONG
HKU BUSINESS SCHOOL

MSMK7045 Retail-Driven Marketing Innovation

GENERAL INFORMATION
Instructor: Gigi KY Cheung E-mail: gigi829@hku.hk; gigic@fbe.hku.hk Office: KK103 TA: TBC E-mail: TBC Consultation time: One hour after each class; appointments should be scheduled in advance. Pre-requisites: N/A Co-requisites: N/A

COURSE DESCRIPTION
Retail-Driven Marketing Innovation examines how organisations create, deliver, and capture value across physical, digital, and omnichannel retail ecosystems. The course focuses on the commercial 'last mile' of marketing, where shopper insight, brand strategy, channel design, customer experience, and conversion come together. Students apply consumer psychology, design thinking, retail strategy, and data-informed decision making to challenges in FMCG, retail stores, shopping malls, luxury, hospitality, e-commerce, and lifestyle brands. Particular attention is given to shopper journeys, trade and category marketing, destination and experiential retail, partnership marketing, retail media, CRM, AI-enabled content and personalisation, and responsible use of customer data. Drawing on cases from Hong Kong, the Greater Bay Area, Mainland China, and global markets, the course connects academic frameworks with managerial practice through cases, field observation, practitioner engagement, and applied exercises. Students learn to evaluate how retail marketing decisions affect traffic, conversion, basket size, loyalty, brand equity, customer lifetime value, and return on investment. The course culminates in an industry-facing capstone project in which students diagnose a live or realistic retail challenge and present an evidence-based innovation proposal that balances customer value, commercial viability, operational feasibility, and responsible business practice.

COURSE OBJECTIVES
1. Analyse evolving retail markets and shopper behaviour using established frameworks in customer value, segmentation, shopper insight, category dynamics, and customer journey analysis.
2. Develop differentiated retail marketing strategies across FMCG, stores, shopping malls, luxury, hospitality, e-commerce, and omnichannel environments using design thinking, experiential marketing, and value-creation frameworks.
3. Integrate physical and digital touchpoints into coherent customer experiences using CRM, retail media, marketplaces, partnerships, content, and selected AI-enabled applications. Aligned Faculty Goals
4. Design and communicate commercially grounded retail solutions by combining academic theory, market research, industry evidence, and performance measures such as traffic, conversion, basket size, loyalty, customer lifetime value, brand equity, and ROI.

PROGRAMME LEARNING OUTCOMES
PLO 1: Acquisition and internalization of knowledge of the programme discipline PLO 2: Application and integration of knowledge PLO 3: Inculcating professionalism and leadership PLO 4: Developing global outlook PLO 5: Mastering communication skills
COURSE LEARNGING OUTCOMES

Course Learning Outcomes	**Aligned Programme Learning Outcomes**
CLO1: Diagnose retail marketing opportunities by analysing shopper insight, consumer behaviour, category dynamics, competitive context, and channel evidence.	PLO 1, 2 & 4
CLO2: Apply innovation and marketing frameworks to reframe retail challenges and develop differentiated, commercially viable value propositions.	PLO 1, 2 & 3
CLO3: Design differentiated retail experiences by integrating empathy, creativity, analytical reasoning, appropriate innovation methods, and responsible AI-enabled marketing tools.	PLO 1, 2 & 3
CLO4: Evaluate FMCG trade marketing, retail-store, mall, luxury, hospitality, and e-commerce strategies using appropriate strategic, customer, and commercial criteria.	PLO 1, 2 & 4
CLO5: Design omnichannel customer journeys and integrated campaigns across physical, social, CRM, marketplace, and e-commerce touchpoints.	PLO 2, 3 & 5
CLO6: Develop measurement approaches linking awareness and engagement to traffic, conversion, basket size, loyalty, customer lifetime value, and ROI, and communicate recommendations with professional clarity.	PLO 2, 3 & 5

COURSE TEACHING AND LEARNING ACTIVITIES		
Course Teaching and Learning Activities	**Expected contact hour**	**Study Load (% of study)**
Lectures, workshops, and in-class discussions Each class introduces a conceptual framework and applied retail issue. Cases, exercises, guest speakers, and selected field observations connect theory with managerial practice.	30	30%
Reading and pre-class preparation Students complete assigned academic articles, cases, and practitioner materials before class and use them in discussions and assessments.	10	10%
Individual learning and assessment Students complete quizzes, an individual retail opportunity analysis, and an integrative reflection that strengthen independent judgement and written communication.	30	30%
Group project learning Teams complete a retail innovation project for a live or realistic organisational challenge, including research, analysis, concept development, commercial evaluation, presentation, and final report.	40	40%
Total	**120**	**100%**

ASSESSMENT METHODS		
Method	**Weight**	**Aligned Course Learning Outcomes**
Professional engagement and participation	15%	CLO1- 6
Individual short quizzes	15%	CLO1, 2, 4 & 6
Individual retail opportunity analysis (2,000 words)	25%	CLO1, 2, 4 & 6
Group industry capstone: presentation and final report	45%	CLO1- 6
Total	**100%**	

STANDARDS FOR ASSESSMENT	
Course Grade Descriptor	
A+, A, A-	Consistently demonstrates outstanding analytical depth, integration of evidence and frameworks, originality, and sound commercial judgement. Develops feasible and differentiated retail innovation recommendations and communicates them with exceptional professional clarity and leadership.
B+, B, B-	Frequently demonstrates strong analysis, effective integration of evidence and frameworks, good commercial judgement, and well-developed retail recommendations. Communicates clearly and contributes effectively to teamwork.
C+, C, C-	Demonstrates satisfactory understanding and application of relevant concepts. Analysis and recommendations are generally appropriate but may lack depth, integration, originality, commercial precision, or communication clarity.
D+, D	Demonstrates only a basic or inconsistent understanding of course concepts. Analysis is limited, evidence is weak, and recommendations show significant gaps in feasibility, integration, or communication.
F	Fails to demonstrate the minimum required understanding or application of course concepts. Work is substantially incomplete, unsupported, commercially implausible, or does not meet academic and professional requirements.

ASSESSMENT RUBRICS FOR EACH ASSESSMENT

1. Professional engagement and participation

Students are expected to attend punctually, complete pre-class preparation, contribute relevant evidence and perspectives, participate constructively in exercises, and demonstrate professional respect for classmates, speakers, and partners.

2. Individual short quizzes

Short quizzes assess understanding and application of core concepts, frameworks, readings, and case material. Quizzes may be administered at the beginning or end of class.

3. Individual retail opportunity analysis (2,000 words)

Students diagnose a retail opportunity for a selected organisation or category. Assessment criteria: problem definition and shopper insight (20%); application of frameworks (25%); quality of research and evidence (20%); commercial and strategic evaluation (25%); professional writing and referencing (10%).

4. Group industry capstone

Teams of 5-6 diagnose a live or realistic organisational challenge and develop a differentiated, feasible, and measurable retail innovation proposal. Deliverables: 15-20 minute presentation, 5-10 minute Q&A, and 2,500-3,000 word final report.

Capstone criteria: understanding of the challenge (15%); shopper and market research (20%); application of course frameworks (20%); originality and customer value (15%); commercial feasibility and measurement plan (15%); communication (10%); teamwork and professionalism (5%). Regular workshops are conducted in class.

AI use: AI-enabled tools may be used where permitted for ideation, analysis, prototyping, or content development. Students must verify outputs, protect confidential information, disclose material use, and remain accountable for the accuracy, originality, and judgement demonstrated in submitted work.

COURSE CONTENT AND TENTATIVE TEACHING SCHEDULE
1. Retail-Driven Marketing Innovation: Shopper Value and Opportunity Diagnosis • Course overview, assessment requirements, and the role of retail in marketing strategy • Customer value, emotional drivers, and the Schwartz value framework • Foundations of retail marketing: 4Ps/7Ps, shopper marketing, and the retail conversion funnel
2. Design Thinking, Segmentation, and FMCG/Trade Marketing • Human-centred design and rapid problem reframing • Segmentation, targeting, positioning, and value propositions • FMCG shopper insight, category growth, product innovation, packaging, merchandising, and trade marketing • Guest speaker from FMCG & applied workshop: redesign and position a FMCG scenario • Introduction to the industry capstone and retail observation brief
3. Shopper Research, Personas, and Customer Journey Mapping • Observation, interviews, secondary research, and responsible use of AI in insight development • Personas, jobs-to-be-done, moments of truth, friction points, and touchpoint analysis • Physical, social, marketplace, CRM, and e-commerce journeys • Team exercise: persona, journey map, and opportunity statement
4. Destination Branding and Shopping Mall Ecosystems • Place and destination positioning • Experiential 7Ps, tenant mix, events, culture, and physical evidence • Mall ecosystems, footfall generation, dwell time, cross-tenant value, and field observation • Field visit to shopping mall on destination-retail case
5. Experiential Retail, Luxury, and Cultural Commerce • Experience design, sensory cues, service encounters, and clienteling • Luxury retail, scarcity, storytelling, travel retail, and collaboration strategy • Blue Ocean Strategy and differentiated value propositions • Customer lifetime value and loyalty in high-involvement categories • Guest speaker from luxury brand on experiential marketing • Check on Industry Capstone project status and Q&A
6. Partnership Marketing, CRM, and Ecosystem Value Creation • Service-Dominant Logic and co-creation • Brand, platform, payment, property, creator, and cultural partnerships • CRM, membership, loyalty, and first-party data • Partnership analysis: strategic fit, mutual value, governance, and measurement
7. Brand Storytelling, Hospitality, and Global Campaign Design • Narrative branding, cultural relevance, and content strategy • Hospitality and lifestyle campaigns across markets • Integrated campaign architecture: paid, owned, earned, retail, and partner channels • Brand transformation case and campaign prototyping workshop
8. AI-Enabled Storytelling, Retail Media, and E-commerce • Generative AI for insight synthesis, content prototyping, personalisation, and search • Retail media, programmatic advertising, marketplace design, and social commerce • Omnichannel integration and online-to-offline conversion • Responsible AI: accuracy, bias, privacy, intellectual property, disclosure, and brand governance • Guest speaker from industry on case sharing
9. Industry Capstone Presentations and Integrative Reflection • Presentation of evidence-based retail innovation proposals to an industry panel • Q&A, feedback, and evaluation of customer value, differentiation, feasibility, and commercial impact • Peer learning: key insight from another team and one improvement to the team's own proposal • Industry Judge Panel to share their comments and insights
10. Integration, Reflection, and Positive Mindset • Synthesis of the major course frameworks and lessons from the industry capstone • Individual reflection on personal learning, professional growth, and leadership • Positive mindset in innovation: curiosity, reframing, experimentation, resilience, and collaboration. • One-minute individual reflection: key learning, changed assumption, and intended future application • Course wrap-up, feedback, and evaluation

READINGS AND REFERENCES

Class 1

- Schwartz, S. H. (2012). An Overview of the Schwartz Theory of Basic Values. Access link
- Stanford Life Design Lab. Designing Your Life course and learning resources. Access link
- 16 Personalities Test: https://www.16personalities.com/free-personality-test
- Personal Values Assessment, Barret Values Centre https://survey.valuescentre.com/survey.html?id=s1TAEQUStmx-pUIle-ma6Q

Class 2

- Brown, T. (2008). Design Thinking. Harvard Business Review. Access link
- Bill Burnett and Dave Evans "This happiness hack from a wildly popular Stanford class can help you create a life you love", Sep 2016.
- https://designthinkingmeite.web.unc.edu/wp-content/uploads/sites/22337/2020/02/Tim-Brown-Design-Thinking.pdf
- American Marketing Association: Retail and Shopper Marketing collection. Access link

Class 3

- Rosenbaum, M. S., Otalora, M. L., & Ramirez, G. C. (2017). How to Create a Realistic Customer Journey Map. Access link
- Interaction Design Foundation "Personas: Why and How You Should Use Them" https://www.interaction-design.org/literature/article/personas-why-and-how-you-should-use-them
- Greeven, M. J., Xin, K., & Yip, G. S. (2021). How Chinese Retailers Are Reinventing the Customer Journey. Access link

Class 4

- Kavaratzis, M., & Ashworth, G. J. (2005). City Branding: An Effective Assertion of Identity or a Transitory Marketing Trick Access link
- Kavaratzis, M., & Ashworth, G. J. (2006). City Branding: An Effective Assertion of Identity or a Transitory Marketing Trick? Place Branding and Public Diplomacy, 2, 183-194. Access link

Class 5

- Kim, W. C., & Mauborgne, R. (2004). Blue Ocean Strategy. Harvard Business Review. Access link
- W Chan Kim and Renee Mauborgne, Blue Ocean Strategy, Harvard Business Review, October 2004 https://hbr.org/2004/10/blue-ocean-strategy
- Moon, Y., & Quelch, J. A. Starbucks: Delivering Customer Service (HBS case). Access link

Class 6

- Vargo, S. L., & Lusch, R. F. (2008). Service-Dominant Logic: Continuing the Evolution. Journal of the Academy of Marketing Science, 36, 1-10. Access link
- To Solve a Tough Problem, Reframe It by Julia Binder and Michael D. Watkins, 2024 https://hbr.org/2024/01/to-solve-a-tough-problem-reframe-it
- Adner, R. (2017). Ecosystem as Structure: An Actionable Construct for Strategy. Access link

Class 7

- Berger, J. Contagious: Why Things Catch On (publisher information). Access link
- Holt, D. B. How Brands Become Icons (publisher information). Access link
- Michael Porter, Creating Shared Value, Harvard Business Review, Jan 2011 https://hbr.org/2011/01/the-big-idea-creating-shared-value
- MITSloan Management Review : Why it's good for business when customers share your values, by Daniel Aronson , published in Feb2024. https://sloanreview.mit.edu/article/why-its-good-for-business-when-customers-share-your-values/
- Starbucks: Delivering Customer Serviceby Youngme Moon, John A.Quelch https://hbsp.harvard.edu/product/504016-PDF-ENG

Class 8

- Brynjolfsson, E., Hu, Y. J., & Rahman, M. S. (2013). Competing in the Age of Omnichannel Retailing. Access link
- Grewal, D. et al. (2025). How Generative AI Is Shaping the Future of Marketing. Access link

Class 9

- Day, G. S. (2007). Is It Real? Can We Win? Is It Worth Doing? Harvard Business Review. Access link
- Farris, P. W. et al. Marketing Metrics (publisher information). Access link

Class 10

- Porter, M. E., & Kramer, M. R. (2011). Creating Shared Value. Harvard Business Review. Access link
- HKU Teaching and Learning: Plagiarism policies and regulations. Access link

MEANS/PROCESSES FOR STUDENT FEEDBACK ON COURSE
A short beginning-of-course survey to understand students' experience, expectations, and sector interests. Ongoing informal feedback and a mid-course pulse check. The HKU Student Feedback on Teaching and Learning (SFTL) questionnaire and end-of-course reflection.

COURSE POLICIES
Students are expected to attend all classes punctually and participate professionally. In case of illness or exceptional circumstances, students should notify the instructor as early as possible and provide supporting documentation where required by University policy.
Assignments must be submitted by the stated deadlines. Requests for extensions or special consideration must be made in advance and will be handled in accordance with applicable University and programme policies.
Academic integrity is essential. All submitted work must be the student's or team's own work, and all sources, data, ideas, images, and material use of AI-enabled tools must be appropriately acknowledged. Plagiarism, fabrication, unauthorised collaboration, and other forms of academic misconduct may lead to disciplinary action. HKU plagiarism policies and regulations